

SOP Starter Pack

50 Standard Operating Procedures for Online Businesses

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How to Use This Pack

Each SOP follows the same format: Purpose, Trigger, Steps, Tools, and Time. Duplicate any SOP into your Notion workspace or copy it into a Google Doc. Fill in the [BRACKETS] with your specifics.

These SOPs are designed for solopreneurs and small teams. They're not corporate templates — they're built for speed.

SECTION 1: CLIENT ONBOARDING (7 SOPs)

SOP 01 — New Client Inquiry Response

Purpose: Respond to every new inquiry within 2 hours in a way that qualifies the lead and moves them to a discovery call.

Trigger: New inquiry arrives via email, contact form, DM, or referral.

Steps:

1. Read the inquiry fully before responding. Note: budget mentioned (yes/no), timeline, specific problem, how they found you.
2. Check your current capacity. If fully booked, skip to step 7.
3. Open your inquiry response template (see below). Personalize the first line with something specific from their message.
4. Include: (a) acknowledgement of their problem, (b) one sentence on how you typically help with this, (c) a link to your calendar or 2-3 time options for a call.
5. Do NOT send your rates in the first reply. Do NOT send a full proposal. Discovery call first.
6. Add the lead to your CRM with status "Lead" and set a follow-up reminder for 3 days if they don't respond.
7. If at capacity: reply with a thank-you, your estimated availability, and ask if they'd like to be added to a waitlist.

Template:

Hi [Name], thanks for reaching out — sounds like you're dealing with [specific problem they mentioned], which is exactly the kind of thing I work on. I'd love to hear more and see if we're a good fit. Are you free for a 20-minute call [Day] or [Day] at [Time]? You can also grab a time directly here: [calendar link]. Talk soon, [Your name]

Tools: Email or DM platform, CRM, calendar tool (Calendly, Cal.com, etc.)

Time required: 5-10 minutes per inquiry

SOP 02 — Discovery Call Checklist & Script

Purpose: Run every discovery call consistently so you qualify leads, understand the problem deeply, and know whether to move forward.

Trigger: Discovery call is booked.

Pre-call prep (15 min before):

1. Review everything the prospect shared in their inquiry.
2. Research their business: website, LinkedIn, recent content. Note 1-2 specific observations.
3. Open a blank doc to take notes during the call.
4. Have your availability and rough project timeline in mind.

Call structure (20-30 min):

1. **(0:00-2:00) Open:** "Thanks for making time — before I jump into questions, just to confirm: you've got about 20-25 minutes, right? Great. I'll ask you some questions, you ask me whatever you want, and by the end we'll both know if it makes sense to move forward."
2. **(2:00-10:00) Their situation:** "Tell me what's going on — what made you reach out now?" Let them talk. Take notes. Don't interrupt.
3. **(10:00-18:00) Go deeper:** Ask: "How long has this been a problem?", "What have you tried?", "What does success look like 3 months from now?", "What's the cost of NOT solving this?"
4. **(18:00-23:00) Your fit:** Briefly explain how you typically help, what the process looks like, rough timeline.
5. **(23:00-28:00) Budget conversation:** "For a project like this, budgets typically range from [X] to [Y]. Does that fit what you're working with?" Wait for them to answer.
6. **(28:00-30:00) Next step:** If it's a fit: "Based on what you've shared, I'd like to put together a proposal. I'll send it over within [timeframe]. Does that work?" If it's not a fit: "I don't think I'm the best fit for this one, but let me point you toward [alternative]."

Post-call (within 30 min):

1. Add notes to CRM immediately while fresh.
2. Update lead status to "Proposal Pending" or "Not a Fit."
3. Send a follow-up email within 1 hour: "Great talking with you — I'll have the proposal over by [date]."

Tools: Video call platform, CRM, notes doc

Time required: 15 min prep + 25 min call + 10 min post

SOP 03 — Proposal Creation & Send

Purpose: Create a proposal that clearly communicates scope, price, and value — and makes it easy for the client to say yes.

Trigger: Discovery call completed and lead is qualified.

Steps:

1. Open your proposal template.
2. Fill in: client name, project name, date, and expiry date (proposals expire in 7 days).
3. Write the **Problem Statement** section: 2-3 sentences describing their situation in their own words (use your discovery call notes). This shows you listened.

4. Write the **Proposed Solution** section: what you'll do, what you won't do, and why this approach works.
5. Write the **Deliverables** section: a clear, numbered list. Be specific. "Website redesign" is bad. "5-page website (Home, About, Services, Blog, Contact) built in Webflow with mobile optimization and 2 rounds of revisions" is good.
6. Write the **Timeline** section: start date, key milestones, delivery date.
7. Write the **Investment** section: total price, payment schedule (e.g., 50% upfront, 50% on delivery), what's included, what's not.
8. Add your **Terms**: revision policy, kill fee, what happens if the project is paused.
9. Review once for clarity. Remove anything that sounds like filler.
10. Send via email with subject: "Proposal for [Project Name] — [Client Name]"
11. Set a follow-up reminder for 3 days if no reply.

Tools: Google Docs, Notion, or proposal tool (Bonsai, HoneyBook, Proposify)

Time required: 45–90 minutes

SOP 04 — Contract Signing & Deposit Collection

Purpose: Get the contract signed and deposit paid before doing any work — no exceptions.

Trigger: Client has verbally or in writing accepted your proposal.

Steps:

1. Prepare the contract. Use your standard template — fill in: client name, project name, deliverables (copy from proposal), total price, payment schedule, start date, revision policy, kill fee clause, IP ownership clause.
2. Send the contract via your signing tool. Include a short email: "Excited to get started — here's the contract to review and sign. Once signed, I'll send the invoice for the first payment so we can lock in your start date."
3. Follow up after 24 hours if unsigned.
4. Once signed, send the deposit invoice immediately. Don't wait.
5. Once deposit is received, add client to your CRM with status "Active," create the project in your project tracker, and send the kickoff email (see SOP 05).

Non-negotiables:

- Never start work before contract is signed.
- Never start work before deposit is received.
- If a client pushes back on either: "I totally understand — I just need these in place to hold your start date and protect us both."

Tools: HelloSign, DocuSign, or PandaDoc for contracts. Stripe, Wise, or PayPal for invoices.

Time required: 20 minutes to prepare + waiting time

SOP 05 — Client Onboarding Email Sequence

Purpose: Welcome the client, set expectations, and build confidence from day one.

Trigger: Contract signed and deposit received.

Day 1 — Welcome Email:

Subject: We're official — here's what happens next

Hi [Name], the contract is signed, deposit received — we're officially underway. Here's what to expect:

- **Your start date:** [Date]
- **First milestone:** [Milestone + date]
- **How we'll communicate:** [Tool — e.g., email, Slack, Loom updates]
- **What I need from you to get started:** [List any assets, access, info needed] I'll send a weekly update every [day] so you always know where things stand. Any questions, reply here. Looking forward to it — [Your name]

Day 3 — Assets Request (if needed):

Subject: Quick thing I need from you

Hi [Name], just a reminder — to stay on schedule I need [specific items] by [date]. If anything's changed, just let me know and we'll adjust the timeline accordingly.

Day 7 — First Update:

Subject: Week 1 update — [Project Name]

Hi [Name], one week in. Here's where we are:  Completed: [List]  In progress: [List]  Next milestone: [Date + what it is] Nothing needed from you right now — I'll be in touch on [date] with the next update.

Tools: Email

Time required: 10 minutes to personalize and send each email

SOP 06 — Setting Up a New Client Project

Purpose: Set up every new project consistently so nothing gets lost and handoffs are smooth.

Trigger: Contract signed and deposit received.

Steps:

1. Create a new project in your project tracker. Add: project name, client name, start date, deadline, budget, and status "In Progress."
2. Create a dedicated folder in your file system (Google Drive / Notion): /Clients/[Client Name]/[Project Name]/ . Add subfolders: Assets, Deliverables, References, Contracts.
3. Save the signed contract and deposit receipt in the Contracts folder.
4. If working with a team/contractor: brief them on the project using a 1-page brief (scope, deadline, style references, client preferences).
5. Set up communication channel if applicable (shared Slack channel, project in Asana/Linear, etc.).
6. Add all key dates to your calendar: milestones, check-in calls, deadline, invoice due dates.
7. Block time in your calendar to work on this project.

Tools: Google Drive or Notion, project manager (Notion, Asana, Linear), calendar

Time required: 20–30 minutes

SOP 07 — Kickoff Meeting Agenda & Prep

Purpose: Start the project with full alignment on goals, process, and communication — so there are no surprises later.

Trigger: Project officially started (contract signed, deposit paid).

Pre-meeting prep:

1. Prepare a 1-page agenda and send to client 24 hours before.
2. List any open questions you have after reviewing the brief.
3. Prepare a brief overview of the process/timeline to walk them through.

Agenda (30-45 minutes):

1. **(5 min) Intros/check-in** if team members are joining.
2. **(10 min) Goals alignment:** "In your own words, what does a successful outcome look like?"
Confirm you're aligned.
3. **(10 min) Scope walkthrough:** Review deliverables line by line. Confirm what's in, what's out.
4. **(5 min) Process & timeline:** Walk through the process step by step. Confirm key dates.
5. **(5 min) Communication:** "I'll send updates every [day]. Best way to reach me is [channel].
My typical response time is [X hours]."
6. **(5 min) Open questions:** Address any open items from your prep.
7. **(Wrap):** "Any questions before we dive in? Great — I'll send a summary of this call within the hour."

Post-meeting (within 1 hour): Send a kickoff summary email with: decisions made, confirmed deliverables, key dates, next step, and what's needed from the client.

Tools: Video call, notes doc, email

Time required: 20 min prep + 35 min call + 15 min summary

SECTION 2: CONTENT CREATION (12 SOPs)

SOP 08 — Blog Post Creation Workflow

Purpose: Publish a well-researched, SEO-optimised blog post from idea to live without skipping steps.

Trigger: Blog post is added to the content calendar with a publish date.

Steps:

1. **Keyword research (20 min):** Confirm the target keyword. Check search volume and competition. Identify 3-5 related terms to include naturally.
2. **Outline (15 min):** Write H2 and H3 headings. Each H2 = one major point. Use your target keyword in the title and at least one H2.
3. **First draft (60-90 min):** Write fast, don't edit. Fill in each section. Aim for 1,200-2,000 words for most posts.
4. **Edit pass 1 (20 min):** Read aloud. Cut anything that doesn't add value. Simplify sentences over 20 words. Remove jargon.

5. **Edit pass 2 (10 min):** Check: Does the intro hook in 2 sentences? Is there a clear CTA at the end? Are subheadings scannable?
6. **SEO check (10 min):** Target keyword in title, first 100 words, one H2, and meta description. Add internal links to 2-3 related posts.
7. **Add visuals (10 min):** Feature image, any in-post graphics or screenshots.
8. **Publish and share (10 min):** Publish, share to newsletter and social, add to content tracker as "Published."

Tools: Google Docs for drafting, WordPress/Webflow for publishing, Ahrefs/UBersuggest for keywords

Time required: 2.5-3.5 hours total

SOP 09 — YouTube Video Production Workflow

Purpose: Produce a high-quality YouTube video consistently from idea to published.

Trigger: Video topic added to content calendar with a filming date.

Steps:

1. **Script/outline (30-45 min):** Write a hook (first 30 seconds), the main content in 3-5 points, and a CTA. For talking-head videos: write a loose script. For tutorial videos: write bullet points and record from them.
2. **B-roll/assets prep (15 min):** Gather any screen recordings, graphics, or footage needed.
3. **Record (30-60 min):** Record in one pass. Don't stop for small mistakes — keep going. Do a second take of the full video if needed.
4. **Edit (60-120 min):** Cut dead air and filler words. Add b-roll, captions, and lower thirds. Add intro and outro. Color correct if needed.
5. **Thumbnail (15 min):** Use your thumbnail template in Canva. Big text + expressive face + simple background.
6. **Upload prep (15 min):** Write title (include keyword), description (300+ words, include links), tags (15-20 relevant tags), end screen cards, chapters.
7. **Publish:** Schedule or publish. Share in newsletter and social.
8. **Track:** Add to content tracker as "Published." Note views at 48 hours and 7 days.

Tools: Camera/screen recorder, CapCut/Premiere/DaVinci for editing, Canva for thumbnails

Time required: 3-5 hours total

SOP 10 — Newsletter Writing & Send Process

Purpose: Write and send a newsletter issue that gets opened, read, and replied to.

Trigger: Newsletter send date on content calendar.

Steps:

1. **Choose the topic (5 min):** One topic per issue. Not three. Check your ideas list if stuck.
2. **Write the subject line first (10 min):** Write 5 options. Pick the one that creates the most curiosity or makes the clearest promise. A/B test if your platform allows it.
3. **Write the email (30-45 min):** Open with 1-2 sentences that hook (a question, a surprising stat, or a bold statement). One main idea. 300-600 words max. End with a question or clear CTA.

4. **Preview text (5 min):** Write 40–70 characters that complement the subject line — not a repeat of it.
5. **Proofread (10 min):** Read aloud. Check all links work. Check CTA is clear.
6. **Send test email to yourself (2 min):** Check formatting on mobile.
7. **Schedule or send.**
8. **Track (next day):** Log open rate, click rate, and replies in your content tracker.

Tools: ConvertKit, Beehiiv, Mailchimp, or similar

Time required: 1–1.5 hours

SOP 11 — Social Media Weekly Planning

Purpose: Plan the entire week's social content in one focused session instead of daily scrambling.

Trigger: Every Monday morning (or Sunday evening).

Steps:

1. Open your content calendar. Review what's due this week.
2. Review last week's top-performing post. Note: what format, what topic, what hook.
3. Plan 3–5 posts for the week. For each, note: platform, format (text/image/video/carousel), topic, and hook.
4. Write or batch-create all posts in one session.
5. Schedule all posts using your scheduling tool.
6. Set aside 15 min/day for engagement (reply to comments, engage with others in your niche).

Weekly content mix:

- 1–2 educational/value posts
- 1 personal/story post
- 1 promotional post (product, service, offer)
- 1 engagement post (question, poll, opinion)

Tools: Buffer, Publer, Later, or native schedulers

Time required: 60–90 minutes per week

SOP 12 — Instagram Post Creation

Purpose: Create and publish an Instagram post that drives engagement and reaches new followers.

Trigger: Instagram post slot in content calendar.

Steps:

1. Choose format: single image, carousel, or Reel.
2. Write caption first: hook in line 1 (before "more"), value in lines 2–5, CTA at end. Keep under 300 words for most posts.
3. Write 3–5 hashtag groups (5–10 hashtags each). Rotate between posts.
4. Create visual in Canva using your brand template. Keep it simple — one clear message per image.
5. For carousels: 5–10 slides. Slide 1 = hook. Slides 2–8 = value. Slide 9–10 = CTA and follow prompt.
6. Download and post. Add location if relevant.

7. Engage with comments in first 60 minutes after posting.

Tools: Canva, Later or native Instagram, hashtag research tool

Time required: 20–40 minutes per post

SOP 13 — LinkedIn Content Workflow

Purpose: Publish consistent LinkedIn content that builds authority in your niche.

Trigger: LinkedIn post slot in content calendar.

Steps:

1. Choose angle: personal story, tactical tip, industry opinion, or behind-the-scenes.
2. Write the hook (line 1 only — this is what people see before clicking "see more"). Make it a pattern interrupt: short, unexpected, or specific.
3. Write the body: short paragraphs (1–3 lines). Use line breaks generously. LinkedIn is not a blog.
4. End with a question to drive comments.
5. No links in the post body (LinkedIn suppresses reach). Put links in the first comment.
6. Optimal post length: 150–300 words for most posts. Up to 600 for storytelling posts.
7. Post between 7–9am or 12–1pm on Tuesday, Wednesday, or Thursday.
8. Engage with comments for 30 minutes after posting.

Time required: 20–30 minutes per post

SOP 14 — Podcast Episode Production

Purpose: Record, edit, and publish a podcast episode consistently.

Trigger: Recording date on content calendar.

Steps:

1. **Prep (30 min):** Write episode outline: hook, 3–5 main points, CTA. Prepare any guest questions. Test mic and recording setup.
2. **Record:** Record intro, main content, outro. Don't stop for small mistakes. Take a short pause before retaking any section.
3. **Edit (30–60 min):** Remove long pauses, filler words ("um," "uh"), and major mistakes. Add intro/outro music. Normalize audio levels.
4. **Show notes (20 min):** Write a 150–250 word description with: what the episode covers, 3–5 bullet points, links mentioned, and guest info if applicable.
5. **Upload:** Upload to your hosting platform (Buzzsprout, Transistor, Anchor). Add title, description, season/episode number, and artwork.
6. **Publish and promote:** Share clip to social, include in newsletter, post audiogram on Instagram/LinkedIn.

Tools: Riverside.fm or Zoom for recording, Descript or Audacity for editing, Buzzsprout for hosting

Time required: 1.5–3 hours total

SOP 15 — Content Repurposing Process

Purpose: Turn one piece of long-form content into 5–8 pieces of short-form content without creating from scratch.

Trigger: Any long-form piece (blog, video, podcast) is published.

Steps:

1. Identify the 3–5 best insights, quotes, or moments from the piece.
2. For each insight, create:
 - 1 LinkedIn post (the insight + 1 paragraph of context)
 - 1 Twitter/X post (the insight in under 280 characters, or as a short thread)
 - 1 Instagram caption (same angle, reformatted for the visual platform)
3. Pull one quote for an Instagram quote card (Canva).
4. Pull one tip for a TikTok/Reel hook: "Here's the thing about [topic] nobody talks about..."
5. Summarise the whole piece in 3 bullet points for a newsletter section.
6. Schedule all pieces across the next 2 weeks — don't post all at once.

Tools: Canva, scheduling tool, your notes from the original piece

Time required: 60–90 minutes to repurpose one long-form piece

SOP 16 — Content Performance Monthly Review

Purpose: Understand what's working so you double down and cut what isn't.

Trigger: First Monday of every month.

Steps:

1. Open your content tracker. Pull data for the past 30 days.
2. For each platform, identify: top 3 posts by reach, top 3 by engagement, bottom 3 by both.
3. Answer: What topics performed best? What formats? What posting times?
4. Look at follower growth this month vs. last month.
5. Check which content drove the most clicks to your site or product.
6. Update your content strategy doc: add what to do more of, what to stop, what to test.
7. Plan next month's content mix based on findings.

Time required: 45–60 minutes

SOP 17 — Graphic Design Request Process

Purpose: Brief a designer (or your own Canva work) clearly so revisions are minimal.

Trigger: Graphic asset needed for content, product, or marketing.

Steps:

1. Complete a design brief with: (a) asset type and dimensions, (b) purpose, (c) key message, (d) brand colors and fonts, (e) visual reference examples (attach 2–3 examples), (f) deadline.
2. Share brief with designer or open Canva.
3. Review first draft against the brief — not against personal preference.
4. Provide feedback in this format: "On [specific element], can you [specific change]?" Not: "I don't know, something feels off."
5. Allow one revision round per brief.

6. Approve final and save to brand assets folder.

Time required: 15 min to brief, 10 min per review

SOP 18 — SEO Optimisation Checklist

Purpose: Ensure every piece of published web content is properly optimised before going live.

Trigger: Before publishing any blog post, landing page, or product page.

Checklist:

- ☐ Target keyword identified and confirmed (search volume > 0, realistic difficulty)
- ☐ Target keyword in: page title, URL slug, first 100 words, at least one H2, meta description
- ☐ Meta description written (150-160 characters, includes keyword, has a hook)
- ☐ Title tag written (50-60 characters, includes keyword, compelling)
- ☐ Alt text added to all images (includes keyword where natural)
- ☐ Internal links: at least 2 links to other relevant pages on your site
- ☐ External links: 1-2 links to authoritative sources
- ☐ Content length appropriate for the topic (1,200+ words for competitive topics)
- ☐ URL is clean and readable (no random characters)
- ☐ Page loads fast (test with Google PageSpeed)
- ☐ Mobile formatting checked

Time required: 15-20 minutes per page

SOP 19 — Content Calendar Management

Purpose: Keep the content calendar organised, up-to-date, and actually used.

Trigger: Weekly, every Monday.

Steps:

1. Open content calendar.
2. Mark all content from last week as Published, Delayed, or Cancelled.
3. Move any delayed content to the next available slot.
4. Confirm all content for the next 7 days has: topic, format, platform, and assigned creator.
5. Check content for the following 2 weeks — flag any gaps or missing ideas.
6. Fill gaps from your ideas backlog.
7. Confirm any content that requires external input (guest posts, collaborations, product launches) is on track.

Time required: 15-20 minutes weekly

SECTION 3: FINANCE & INVOICING (8 SOPs)

SOP 20 — Creating & Sending Invoices

Purpose: Send professional invoices that get paid on time.

Trigger: Project milestone reached, or monthly billing date.

Steps:

1. Open your invoicing tool.
2. Create a new invoice. Fill in: invoice number, client name and address, issue date, due date (net 14 days is standard), line items with clear descriptions, amounts, and totals.
3. Add your payment details: bank transfer details, or Stripe/PayPal link.
4. Add your late payment policy in the footer (e.g., "Invoices unpaid after 30 days incur a 2% monthly fee").
5. Review for accuracy — especially the total and due date.
6. Send with a short, professional email: "Hi [Name], attached is invoice #[X] for [project/month]. Total: [amount], due by [date]. Let me know if you have any questions."
7. Add invoice to your invoice tracker with status "Sent."
8. Set a reminder for 2 days before the due date to follow up if unpaid.

Tools: Wave (free), FreshBooks, QuickBooks, or Stripe Invoicing

Time required: 10–15 minutes per invoice

SOP 21 — Following Up on Overdue Payments

Purpose: Recover overdue payments professionally without damaging the client relationship.

Trigger: Invoice due date has passed and payment not received.

Day 1 past due — Friendly reminder:

Subject: Invoice #[X] — Quick reminder Hi [Name], just a quick note — invoice #[X] for [amount] was due yesterday. It may have slipped through! You can pay via [link/method]. Let me know if you have any questions.

Day 7 past due — Direct follow-up:

Subject: Invoice #[X] — Following up Hi [Name], following up on invoice #[X] for [amount], now [7] days overdue. Could you let me know the expected payment date? I want to make sure this doesn't affect our ongoing work. Payment can be made here: [link].

Day 14 past due — Firm notice:

Subject: Invoice #[X] — Action required Hi [Name], invoice #[X] for [amount] is now 14 days overdue. Per our contract, late payment fees of [X]% now apply. I need payment by [specific date] to continue our work together. If there's an issue on your end, please reach out so we can resolve it.

Day 30 past due: Pause work. Send a formal notice. If no response, consult your contract's dispute resolution clause. Consider using a collections service for amounts over [your threshold].

Time required: 5 minutes per follow-up

SOP 22 — Monthly Bookkeeping Process

Purpose: Keep your books clean every month so tax time is not a disaster.

Trigger: First business day of each month.

Steps:

1. Download all bank and card statements for the previous month.
2. Open your accounting tool. Categorise all transactions if not auto-categorised.
3. Match all invoices paid against your invoice tracker. Mark as "Paid" in your tracker.
4. Add any expenses not yet recorded: subscriptions, tools, contractor payments.
5. Review the monthly P&L: revenue, expenses, net profit. Compare to last month and to your goal.
6. Flag any unusual items.
7. Save the month's P&L summary in your finance folder.

Tools: Wave, QuickBooks, FreshBooks, or a spreadsheet

Time required: 30-60 minutes monthly

SOP 23 — Expense Tracking & Categorisation

Purpose: Track every business expense in real time so nothing is missed at tax time.

Trigger: Any business expense is made.

Steps:

1. When you make a purchase: save the receipt immediately (photo, email, or download).
2. Log it in your expense tracker: date, vendor, amount, category, purpose.
3. Categories to use: Software & Tools, Contractor Payments, Marketing & Ads, Education & Training, Office & Equipment, Travel, Professional Services, Other.
4. Mark tax-deductible status (consult your accountant for local rules).
5. Batch-review and reconcile expenses weekly during your weekly review.

Time required: 2 minutes per expense, 15 minutes weekly for reconciliation

SOP 24 — Quarterly Tax Preparation

Purpose: Stay on top of taxes quarterly so you're never scrambling at year-end.

Trigger: End of each quarter (March, June, September, December).

Steps:

1. Pull your P&L for the quarter from your accounting tool.
2. Calculate estimated tax owed (consult your accountant or use your country's standard rate).
3. Set aside that amount in a dedicated savings account if not already done.
4. Review deductible expenses: ensure all are categorised correctly.
5. Send a summary to your accountant (if you have one) for their review.
6. File quarterly tax return if required in your country.
7. Review: Am I on track with annual revenue goals? Do I need to adjust pricing or spending?

Time required: 1-2 hours quarterly

SOP 25 — Pricing a New Service or Project

Purpose: Set a price that reflects the value you deliver, covers your costs, and is sustainable.

Trigger: New service offering or custom project quote needed.

Steps:

1. Calculate your minimum: (monthly expenses + desired monthly take-home) ÷ number of clients = minimum per client.
2. Research market rates: check what 3–5 competitors charge for similar work.
3. Assess the value to the client: what is solving this problem worth to them in revenue or time saved?
4. Price at the intersection of your minimum, market rates, and value.
5. For custom projects: scope the hours needed × your hourly rate × 1.3 (buffer for scope creep).
Or use project-based pricing if you can scope it tightly.
6. Test the price: say it out loud before sending. If you cringe, it might be too low.
7. Add to your services document or rate card.

Time required: 30–60 minutes

SOP 26 — End-of-Year Financial Review

Purpose: Understand your business financials for the year and set clear targets for next year.

Trigger: December 15–31 each year.

Steps:

1. Pull annual P&L from your accounting tool.
2. Calculate: total revenue, total expenses, net profit, effective hourly rate (total revenue ÷ total hours worked).
3. Review by month: which months were highest/lowest? Why?
4. Review by client/service: which generated most revenue? Most profit? Which were most trouble?
5. Review expenses: what can be cut? What should be increased?
6. Set revenue goal for next year. Break down by month.
7. Identify 1–2 pricing or service changes for next year.
8. Send year-end summary to accountant.

Time required: 2–3 hours

SOP 27 — Refund Request Handling

Purpose: Handle refund requests quickly and professionally, protecting your reputation and your cash.

Trigger: Client or customer requests a refund.

Steps:

1. Acknowledge within 24 hours: "Thanks for reaching out — I've received your refund request and will review it within 2 business days."
2. Review: Does this request fall within your refund policy? Is the request legitimate?
3. If within policy: process the refund, notify the client, and log in your revenue tracker as a refund.

4. If outside policy: reply with: "I've reviewed your request — per our agreement, [reason it doesn't qualify]. I'm not able to issue a refund in this case, but here's what I can do: [alternative, e.g. extra revision, partial credit]."
5. For digital products: issue a refund if within your stated policy period (e.g., 30 days). No need to verify "why" — just honour it. The goodwill is worth more than the sale.
6. Log all refunds. If you see a pattern, investigate your product or delivery.

Time required: 15–30 minutes per case

SECTION 4: PROJECT MANAGEMENT (8 SOPs)

SOP 28 — New Project Setup

Purpose: Get every project set up identically so nothing gets missed and handoffs are smooth.

(See SOP 06 — same process applies here as the detailed version.)

Quick checklist:

- ☐ Project created in project tracker
- ☐ Client folder created in file system
- ☐ Key dates added to calendar
- ☐ Team/contractors briefed (if applicable)
- ☐ Communication channel established
- ☐ First milestone confirmed with client

Time required: 20 minutes

SOP 29 — Weekly Project Status Review

Purpose: Know the status of every active project every week without relying on memory.

Trigger: Every Monday morning.

Steps:

1. Open your project tracker. Review all projects with status "In Progress."
2. For each project: is it on track for this week's milestone? Yes / At risk / Behind.
3. For any "At risk" or "Behind" projects: identify the blocker and the solution. Is it waiting on the client? Notify them now. Is it on your side? Reschedule to this week.
4. Update the status in your tracker.
5. Send a brief client update to any project where something has changed (see SOP 30 for format).
6. Update your weekly priorities based on what's most urgent.

Time required: 20–30 minutes weekly

SOP 30 — Client Feedback Collection

Purpose: Get specific, actionable feedback from clients without chasing them.

Trigger: Major milestone delivered or project completed.

Steps:

1. Send deliverable with a clear context email: what it is, what decision you need from them, and the deadline for feedback.
2. Ask for structured feedback: "For each section, please note: what's working, what needs to change, and if anything needs to be added or removed."
3. Give them a specific deadline: "Please send feedback by [date] so we stay on schedule."
4. If no feedback by deadline: follow up once. State the impact: "Without feedback by [new date], I'll need to push the next milestone by [X days]."
5. Compile all feedback into one document before making changes. Don't act on partial feedback.
6. Confirm all changes in a reply: "I've made the following changes based on your feedback: [list]. Let me know if anything looks off."

Time required: 10 min to send, variable review time

SOP 31 — Revision Request Handling

Purpose: Handle revision requests without scope creep and without damaging client relationships.

Trigger: Client requests changes to a deliverable.

Steps:

1. Review the revision request against your contract's revision policy.
2. If within scope: acknowledge, make the changes, deliver with a note of what was changed.
3. If outside scope (new features, different direction): reply with: "I've reviewed your request — [specific change] falls outside the original scope. I can add this as an additional project at [rate/price]. Would you like to proceed?"
4. Never just say yes to out-of-scope work without pricing it. Once you do it for free, they'll expect it forever.
5. Log all revision requests. If a client consistently requests out-of-scope work, address it in your next contract.

Time required: 10–20 minutes per revision cycle

SOP 32 — Project Completion & Handoff

Purpose: Close out every project cleanly and set up future work.

Trigger: All deliverables accepted by client.

Steps:

1. Deliver final files in agreed format to agreed location (shared folder, email, download link).
2. Send final invoice if applicable.
3. Send a completion email: "The project is officially wrapped. Here's what was delivered: [list]. [Link to files]. It's been great working with you — let me know if you need anything."
4. Archive the project in your project tracker (status: Completed).
5. Move client to "Completed" status in CRM. Add notes: what worked, what didn't, any future opportunities.
6. Within 1 week: send a testimonial/referral request (see SOP email templates).

7. Schedule a 30-day check-in in your calendar to follow up on results.

Time required: 30 minutes

SOP 33 — Project Retrospective

Purpose: Learn from every project so you improve your process and protect your profit margin.

Trigger: Within 48 hours of project completion.

Steps:

1. Open a new retrospective doc.
2. Answer these questions:
 - Did we deliver on time? If not, why?
 - Did we deliver within budget (hours)? If not, where did it go?
 - What went well that we should repeat?
 - What went wrong that we should fix?
 - What would we scope differently next time?
 - What was the client's satisfaction level (1-10)?
 - Would we work with this client again?
3. Save the retrospective in the project folder.
4. Add any process improvements to your SOP updates list.

Time required: 20 minutes

SOP 34 — Scope Creep Response

Purpose: Catch and address scope creep before it erodes your margin.

Trigger: Client requests something not in the original scope, OR you notice the project expanding beyond what was agreed.

Script:

"Thanks for sharing this — I want to make sure we can deliver it properly. Looking at the original scope, [requested item] isn't included in our current project. I can add it as a change order at [price/rate], or we can note it for a future project. Which would you prefer?"

If they push back:

"I completely understand — and I want to be able to help. The reason I keep the original scope tight is so I can deliver the agreed work at the quality and timeline we committed to. Taking on additional items without adjusting the budget or timeline would compromise both."

Time required: 5 minutes per conversation

SOP 35 — Urgent/Rush Request Handling

Purpose: Handle last-minute urgent requests without disrupting your existing client work.

Trigger: Client requests rushed delivery outside of agreed timeline.

Steps:

1. Assess the request: can it realistically be done in the timeframe?
2. Review your current schedule: what would need to be pushed to accommodate this?
3. If you can accommodate: quote a rush fee (typically 25–50% above standard rate). Clearly state what you'll deliver and by when.
4. If you can't accommodate: "I'd love to help with this, but I'm fully committed through [date]. I can start on [earliest date] — would that work?"
5. Never accept rush work without a rush fee. It sets a precedent.
6. Deliver on the rush deadline, or don't take the work.

Time required: 10–15 minutes to respond and scope

SECTION 5: TEAM & DELEGATION (8 SOPs)

SOP 36 — Hiring a Contractor

Purpose: Find and hire the right contractor without wasting time on bad fits.

Trigger: Workload requires outside help or you're building a service you can't deliver alone.

Steps:

1. Write a job description: what you need done, required skills, time commitment (hours/week), project type (one-off vs. ongoing), and budget.
2. Post on: Toptal (premium), Upwork, LinkedIn, or relevant communities/Slack groups.
3. Review applicants: look for portfolio quality, communication clarity, and relevance. Ignore applications that are clearly copy-pasted.
4. Shortlist 3 candidates. Send a short test task (paid, max 1–2 hours of work).
5. Select based on: quality of test, communication speed and clarity, and price.
6. Sign a contract (scope, rate, payment terms, confidentiality, IP ownership).
7. Onboard (see SOP 37).

Time required: 2–4 hours total across the process

SOP 37 — Contractor Onboarding

Purpose: Get a new contractor up to speed quickly so they can produce quality work independently.

Trigger: Contractor hired and contract signed.

Steps:

1. Send access credentials to all needed tools.
2. Share a "start here" doc with: company overview, your brand voice and style guide, what good work looks like (examples), how you communicate and give feedback, deadlines and delivery expectations.
3. Assign first task: make it smaller than typical so you can evaluate quality before entrusting larger work.
4. Review first deliverable closely. Give detailed feedback.
5. Schedule a brief 15-minute check-in for their first week.

Time required: 1–2 hours to set up, 30 min for first check-in

SOP 38 — Task Delegation Checklist

Purpose: Delegate tasks clearly so they come back right the first time.

Trigger: Any task you're handing to a team member or contractor.

Before you delegate, confirm you can answer all of these:

- ☐ What is the deliverable (specifically)?
- ☐ What does "done" look like? (Describe the end state)
- ☐ What are the constraints? (Format, length, style, tools to use)
- ☐ What is the deadline?
- ☐ What is the priority relative to other work?
- ☐ Where should they send the finished work?
- ☐ Who can they ask if they have questions?
- ☐ What reference materials or examples can you give them?

Write this out and send it with the task. Don't delegate verbally without a written brief.

Time required: 5-10 minutes per delegation

SOP 39 — Weekly Team Check-In

Purpose: Keep everyone aligned and unblocked without endless meetings.

Trigger: Weekly, same day and time every week.

Format (15-20 minutes):

1. Each team member shares (async via Loom/Notion, or in a quick sync):
 - What I completed last week
 - What I'm working on this week
 - Any blockers
2. Review priorities together. Reassign if needed.
3. Note any blockers and resolve them in the meeting or assign owners to resolve them by EOD.

Async option: Post a weekly check-in template in Slack/Notion. Everyone fills it in by Monday 10am. Only escalate to a live call if there are blockers to resolve.

Time required: 15-20 minutes

SOP 40 — Contractor Performance Review

Purpose: Evaluate contractors regularly so you keep the good ones and address problems early.

Trigger: Monthly for ongoing contractors. After each project for one-off work.

Steps:

1. Review their work for the period: quality, timeliness, communication.
2. Rate on a simple 1-5 scale: Quality / Reliability / Communication / Value for money.

3. If average ≥ 4 : tell them. People who feel valued stay. Consider a small rate increase if they've been with you 6+ months.
4. If average 3: schedule a brief conversation. Share specific examples of what needs to improve. Give a clear timeframe.
5. If average ≤ 2 : begin the offboarding process (see SOP 41).

Time required: 20–30 minutes monthly

SOP 41 — Contractor Offboarding

Purpose: End a contractor relationship cleanly, professionally, and without legal risk.

Trigger: Project completed, contract term ended, or performance is not meeting standards.

Steps:

1. Review the contract: notice period, final payment terms.
2. Send a written notice: "We're wrapping up our working relationship as of [date]. Your final invoice should cover [period]. Thank you for your work."
3. Revoke all tool access on the final day.
4. Collect all work files, passwords, or assets they hold.
5. Pay the final invoice within the agreed timeframe.
6. Add a note to your contractor tracker: would you hire again? Why/why not?

Time required: 30 minutes

SOP 42 — Creating Training Materials

Purpose: Document recurring processes so contractors and new hires can onboard without needing you for every question.

Trigger: Any process you've had to explain more than twice.

Steps:

1. Do the task once while recording your screen (Loom works well).
2. Write a step-by-step written version alongside the video.
3. Include: purpose, trigger, numbered steps, tools used, what done looks like.
4. Store in your shared SOP folder.
5. When assigning the task: send the SOP. Don't re-explain. Trust the SOP.
6. Update the SOP when the process changes.

Time required: 20–30 minutes per SOP created

SOP 43 — Managing Revisions From a Contractor

Purpose: Get quality revisions from contractors without re-doing the work yourself.

Trigger: Contractor deliverable needs changes before it's client-ready.

Steps:

1. Review the deliverable against the original brief before sending feedback.

2. Write feedback in specific, actionable language: "On section 2, please change X to Y" — not "this doesn't feel right."
3. Prioritise feedback: mark what's essential vs. nice-to-have.
4. Set a clear revision deadline.
5. If a contractor consistently delivers work that needs major revisions: the brief is the problem OR the contractor is the problem. Determine which before acting.
6. After 2–3 rounds of major revisions on the same task type: update your brief template to prevent it.

Time required: 15–30 minutes per revision cycle

SECTION 6: TOOLS & TECH (7 SOPs)

SOP 44 — Weekly Tool & Software Audit

Purpose: Keep your tool stack lean, functional, and cost-effective.

Trigger: First Monday of every month (or quarterly if tools are stable).

Steps:

1. List all active subscriptions and their monthly costs.
2. For each tool: Am I using it at least weekly? Is there a cheaper/free alternative? Is it doing its job?
3. Cancel any tool not used in the past 30 days.
4. Check for duplicate tools (e.g., two project managers, two schedulers) and consolidate.
5. Note any tools that are causing friction or missing features — research alternatives quarterly.

Time required: 20 minutes monthly

SOP 45 — Password & Security Management

Purpose: Keep your accounts secure without losing access to critical tools.

Steps (setup, do once):

1. Use a password manager: 1Password or Bitwarden (free).
2. Generate unique strong passwords for every account — never reuse.
3. Enable 2FA on: email, banking, Stripe/payment processors, domain registrar, hosting, social media, password manager.
4. Store backup codes for 2FA-enabled accounts in your password manager's secure notes.
5. Add emergency access contact in your password manager.

Monthly check:

1. Review new accounts added this month — are they in the password manager?
2. Check for any security alerts from your email or password manager.

Time required: 1 hour setup, 10 minutes monthly

SOP 46 — File Organisation & Naming Convention

Purpose: Find any file in under 30 seconds. Always.

Folder structure:

```
Business/
├── Clients/
│   ├── [Client Name]/
│   │   ├── Contracts/
│   │   ├── Assets/
│   │   ├── Deliverables/
│   │   └── Correspondence/
├── Finance/
│   ├── Invoices/
│   ├── Expenses/
│   └── Tax/
├── Content/
│   ├── Blog/
│   ├── Social/
│   └── Newsletter/
├── Brand/
│   ├── Logos/
│   ├── Fonts/
│   └── Colors/
└── Admin/
    ├── Contracts-Templates/
    ├── SOPs/
    └── Legal/
```

Naming convention: YYYY-MM-DD_ClientName_DocumentType_Version

Examples:

- 2026-06-15_Acme_Invoice_001.pdf
- 2026-06-15_Acme_Contract_Signed.pdf
- 2026-06-15_BlogPost_AITools_Draft1.docx

Rule: Name the file before you save it. Never use "Untitled" or "Copy of."

Time required: 30 min to set up, 2 min per file saved

SOP 47 — Daily Email Inbox Management

Purpose: Process your email inbox to zero every day without it consuming your day.

Trigger: Once in the morning, once in the afternoon. Email is NOT always-on.

Steps:

1. Set specific email times: 9am and 4pm. Do not check outside these windows.
2. For each email, make an immediate decision:
 - **Respond now** (takes < 3 min): respond and archive.
 - **Schedule** (needs > 3 min): add to task manager, archive the email.
 - **Delegate**: forward, archive.
 - **Reference**: file in appropriate folder, archive.

- **Delete:** newsletters you don't read, automated notifications, spam.
- 3. Inbox should be at zero after each session.
- 4. Unsubscribe from any newsletter you delete without reading 3 times in a row.

Time required: 20–30 minutes per session

SOP 48 — CRM Maintenance & Cleanup

Purpose: Keep your CRM accurate so it's useful, not just a graveyard of old contacts.

Trigger: Monthly, first Monday.

Steps:

1. Review all contacts with status "Lead" older than 60 days. Move dead leads to "Closed - Lost."
2. Review all contacts with status "Proposal Sent" older than 21 days. Follow up or close.
3. Update any contacts with outdated info (email changed, company changed).
4. Archive completed projects and move clients to "Past Client" status.
5. Check your follow-up queue: anyone due a check-in this month?
6. Look at your "Source" field: where did the best clients come from this quarter? Double down on that channel.

Time required: 20–30 minutes monthly

SOP 49 — Website Backup & Maintenance

Purpose: Ensure your website never goes down permanently and always represents you professionally.

Weekly:

- ☐ Check site is live and loading quickly (use uptimerobot.com for free monitoring)
- ☐ Review any error notifications from your hosting or plugin updates

Monthly:

- ☐ Run a full backup of the site (most hosts do this automatically — verify)
- ☐ Update all plugins and themes (if WordPress/similar)
- ☐ Check all contact forms and CTAs are working
- ☐ Review Google Analytics for any traffic drop or anomaly
- ☐ Check page speed with Google PageSpeed Insights

Quarterly:

- ☐ Review all pages for outdated content, broken links, or old pricing
- ☐ Test checkout or booking flow end-to-end
- ☐ Review hosting plan: are you on the right tier?

Time required: 10 min weekly, 30 min monthly, 60 min quarterly

SOP 50 — Quarterly Tech Stack Review

Purpose: Ensure your tools are still the right tools as your business evolves.

Trigger: First week of each quarter.

Steps:

1. List every tool you're paying for. Total the monthly and annual cost.
2. For each tool, rate: How often do I use it? (Daily / Weekly / Monthly / Rarely) and Could I replace it with something cheaper or better?
3. Research any tools rated "Rarely" — cancel or replace.
4. Identify your biggest workflow friction point this quarter. Research solutions.
5. Identify any new tools you started using — add to your official stack and set up properly (account, billing in business name, proper credentials stored in password manager).
6. Update your "official tools list" doc.

Time required: 45-60 minutes quarterly

End of SOP Starter Pack — 50 SOPs complete.

Questions? Reach out at mdbush.vercel.app